

Adorno and Horkheimer: Nightfall

In their examination on the self-destructive attitude of Western reason, which apexed in events such as the National Socialist terror, Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno arrived at a chiasmic conclusion in their joint work, *Dialectic of Enlightenment*. If one were to walk away from this piece with only one lesson, it would be to remember, “Just as myths already entail enlightenment, with every step enlightenment entangles itself more deeply in mythology” (Horkheimer, Adorno, 8). While seemingly unexceptional among the various contradictory statements made by thinkers across history, this one paradox has been a topic of discussion for many readers of what is undoubtedly the most influential publication of the Frankfurt School. Notably, the fundamental ideas of the book have been a subject of comparison to more controversial figures. In his own investigation of critical theory’s sacred text, “The Philosophical Discourse of Modernity”, Jurgen Habermas acknowledges his previous instructor’s affinity toward Machiavelli, Hobbes, and Mandeville (106) on the contingency that those writers, while lords of dissonance, still maintained a constructive attitude in their writing and had open connections to broader Marxist theory. However, that uneasy alliance is gone once the “dark” writers are ousted by the “black” writers. Among this new, uncompromising legion are figures like Marquis de Sade and Friedrich Nietzsche, whose suffocating presences leave no room for the hope in a liberating force of enlightenment.

It is not difficult to sympathize with Adorno and Horkheimer in their belief that enlightenment, which is posited as a step forward in intellect that aims to liberate humans from their fears, is filled with a victorious, yet ruining energy (“The Concept of Enlightenment”, 1). At the empirical level, the knowledge obtained in the post-historic era which led to the development

of livelihood-raising technologies isn't so much the result of a well-crafted enquiry into nature as it is a good amount of luck (Horkheimer, Adorno, 1), driven by traditionalists who did not care for critical theory and took their own opinions for knowledge. For example, Horkheimer and Adorno cite the chronic influence of wealth and power in the pursuit of knowledge and, personifying Francis Bacon, explain that if knowledge were truly obtained without outside influence, would establish mankind's absolute dominion of nature. As the age old saying goes, knowledge is power, yet Horkheimer and Adorno take it one step forward. They elaborate that this knowledge, which is power, knows no end, both in the exploitation of its terraforming capabilities and its submission to "worldly masters" (Horkheimer, Adorno, 2). Let's continue with the technological analogy; technology, like knowledge, serves without bias in a capitalist economy. It does not produce concept, or any feelings associated with knowledge, only methods and mere instruments. To put it another way, it is as democratic as the economic system with which it evolved (Horkheimer, Adorno, 2). However, as we have already established a capitalist society, there is not much to go around. The nail in the coffin, then, must be enlightenment, which has eliminated the remaining remnants of its own self-awareness. By treating itself the same way it treats nature, any knowledge that is theory is simply a means to an end.

The consequences of this rationalized, disenchanted world are what draw the comparison for Habermas between Adorno and Horkheimer to the "black" writers. Firstly, in a similar fashion to Marx's fetishism of the commodity, bourgeois society is dictated by the equivalence factor (Horkheimer, Adorno, 4), meaning for the Enlightenment, anything that cannot be quantified is declared mere illusion. Consequently, gods, spirits, and the supernatural are destroyed, but only in their original form. Instead, the pagan sprites and spirits are replaced by heaven and the oppressive force of the church (Horkheimer, Adorno, 5) and the free-spirited

practices of the magician by the carefully calculated sacrifice and labor of exploited men. In addition, the Olympians are no longer one-in-the-same with the elements but embody them as a kind of avatar. For example, as shown in Homer, Zeus now commands daylight and Apollo guides the sun; deities separate themselves from material to become their aspects. The line to Nietzsche, then, lies in domination, because for Nietzsche, there is no good-faith reasoning, there is only power. That is what Habermas accuses his teachers of forwarding, but might there be merit in their statements? Continuing, Horkheimer and Adorno claim that the price for increasing human power is the estrangement from that which the power exerts itself over (Horkheimer, Adorno, 6). As a result, enlightenment has the same relationship with things that dictators have with human beings; they only understand each other to the extent that the former controls the latter. For example, the scientist knows things up to the point that he can make them, but when the essence of things is uncovered through its transformation, the story remains the same, one of domination, less a substrate of it.

Habermas' comparison of Adorno and Horkheimer's critical theory of the enlightenment to Nietzsche is furthered when we take Nietzsche's genealogical critique of master and slave morality into consideration. To preface, the master and slave morality found in Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morality* essentially states that master morality originates from the strong and the slave morality originates from the weak. The master, to Nietzsche, does not think of themselves in relation to others. They are constantly enthralled by themselves, as the essence of master morality is nobility, in a state of permanent narcissism. They enjoy being on top simply because they describe everything beneath them as "bad." And so, the masters are the ones who create morality, but the slaves respond to master morality with slave morality. Slave morality, which is not a sentiment like master morality, is a type of "ressentiment", meaning it seeks to

devalue what the master exalts and turn weakness into strength. It is created in direct opposition to master morality and all that it values as “good.” The problem that Nietzsche has with master morality is that, to us, it is simply amoral, as there is no capacity to evaluate whether it is moral or not. If you are good, then by definition your actions cannot be bad because there is no distinction between self and action. According to Horkheimer and Adorno, a similar dynamic plays out between the pre-historic and post-enlightenment perspective. Although the magician wards off evil spirits, he does so not by forsaking their existence, but by imitating their gestures (Horkheimer, Adorno, 6). However, even if his task was impersonation, “he did not claim to be made in the image of the invisible power.” It is this forgetting of how things came to be that worried Nietzsche in his analysis of morality and why he specifically underscored the importance of a genealogical approach. We should never worship a moral absolute nor judge something by what it appears to be, but rather, how it continues from its genesis. For Horkheimer and Adorno, the price of forgetting that civilized man will have to pay is the change from a modest hunting ground “to the unified cosmos, in which nothing exists but prey” (Horkheimer, Adorno, 6). Coincidence or not, they invoke language reminiscent of the metaphor of the lambs and birds of prey, in which the lambs claim to be good simply because they are lambs, and the birds of prey are evil simply because they must kill the lambs.

In the same way that Nietzsche saw morality not from a place of purity or love, but risen from violence and an eternal hatred, Horkheimer and Adorno saw enlightenment originate from people’s fear. To elaborate, humans believe themselves to be free of fear when they have conquered the fear of the unknown (Horkheimer, Adorno, 11). This creed has determined the path of enlightenment, which is also the path of demythologization. Unfortunately, the result is that enlightenment becomes mythical fear radicalized. This is because the constant deterrence of

the unknown means that enlightenment must produce a sort of “immanence of positivism”, which in reality is an impossible taboo to maintain (Adorno, Horkheimer, 11). Nothing is allowed to remain outside the human domain, for anything that does is synonymous with the original fear that drove our search for understanding. As a result, we are stuck in a state of cosmic horror; the only thing we have to lose is our entire self-preservation, and yet there’ll always be questions left unanswered and secrets whispered in the dark. However, was it not the point of enlightenment to eliminate such unknown variables? Adorno and Horkheimer think it is perhaps better for us to frame enlightenment’s mythic terror as sprung from a horror of myth (Horkheimer, Adorno, 22). In other words, enlightenment was sought as an escape from people’s fear, specifically, the fear of not being the self, but as we attempted to move away from this realm, we have become the very masters of fear in a fateful dialectic. By actively seeking self-preservation, this endeavor has become the sole basis of virtue.

With all of this in mind, Habermas makes the case that instead of maintaining a healthy amount of cynicism, his teachers have fallen into a trap of self-destruction. By making the normative case that the “return” to a pre-historic era is incredibly dangerous, which does have some merit as fascism constantly posits ideas of an original of sorts, Horkheimer and Adorno essentially mean that the only way out of this paradoxical equation is Nietzsche and his fellow “black” writers. And while we can find some truths to their writing, they are a far cry from the liberal-progressivist thinkers who continue to put value in enlightenment. For example, Habermas, while acknowledging that religion and metaphysics are themselves the result of demythologization (Habermas, 115), believes that rationalization does not stop at these intangible concepts. Instead, the sphere of validity relations is not only cleansed of impurities, but also gets categorized in terms of perspectives aligned with the truth, prescriptive correctness,

and authenticity (albeit subjective thought). While we're interested in the truth, Habermas reminds us that we're also interested in the translation of ideas in the material world. He argues that modernity has given us the ability to make rational claims and engage in rational discourse, that it has left us with a bountiful harvest that the "black" writers can simply never enjoy: education, science, journalism, and art. On the matter of art, Nietzsche is especially dismal as he believes reason to be the origin of artistic fruition, yet he extends that logic to everyone outside of the artistic sphere as well, making it entirely unnecessary (Habermas, 128). Since everyone is an artist, everyone is a little tyrant in the eyes of Nietzsche; their judgement is a way for their values to triumph over the value of others.

By following in their footsteps, Habermas accuses his teachers of abandoning the grounds of philosophy and filling that void with indulging paradox (Habermas, 128). The result is nothing short of aporetic, defeatist, filled with stasis, and imprisoning oneself within their own critical theory. Habermas hypothesizes that any shred of confidence Horkheimer and Adorno maintained was completely exhausted by the beginning of the 1940's. By then, they considered Marxian ideological critique obsolete and no longer put any faith in the redeeming qualities of a critical theory of society (Habermas, 118). Virtually, Habermas found his teachers to be too traumatized by the rise of fascism to see clearly, which inevitably led to their belief that "everything was deception." The problem, however, is that once you critique the very foundation on which you stand, there is nothing left but a type of performative contradiction. As an alternative, let the thinkers make a case for aesthetic practice and aesthetic experience, for there will always be a necessity for social movements to meet the socialization of production.